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Call of the Wild

Natural habitats often deliver on their promise of surprise and rejuvenation, but here are 10 Indian reserves that never fail to please and excite

It is an oft-repeated axiom that India is a country with immense diversity. This is as true for its natural habitats as it is for its people and culture. Although I have lived here for over 40 years and for many of those decades worked in wildlife areas, there remain many protected areas to which I have never been. When India's Wildlife Act was enacted in 1972, there were only five National Parks and around 36 sanctuaries. Fifty years on, in 2022, there are over 950 areas specifically protected as areas of conservation concern. These are all important habitats, so for me, the "best" are the ones I have most enjoyed or with which I am most familiar.

Hemis National Park

The park in the trans-Himalaya of Ladakh is another incredible area in which I have been fortunate enough to reside. Camping in temperatures of -20°C, at over 4,000 m took away none of the pleasure of being in such stunning landscape. The wild sheep and goats, the lammergeiers and golden eagles, the marmots and mouse hares and, of course, the several carnivores all fascinated. It is a high-altitude desert area which may appear austere and unoccupied, but is, in fact, home to the highest variety of mountain prey species—good for the wolves, snow leopards and wild dogs that feed on them.



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Dachigam National Park

My first abode in India, it's still one of my favourite places. The park is in a mountainous region just outside of Srinagar, in **Kashmir**, and is the only home of India's highly endangered member of the central Asian red deer family, the *hangul* or Kashmir stag. It is also an amazing place to see the Himalayan black bear, especially in autumn when they are feeding up on nuts and acorns before their winter hibernation. The landscape is beautiful and changes with each season: winter, spring, summer and autumn—white, pink, green and burnt orange.

Changthang Sanctuary

*Further to the east in **Ladakh** is the Changthang Sanctuary, covering much of the western limit of the Tibetan plateau in India. Here lie wonderful wetlands, self-drainage lakes that provide peaceful nesting areas for migrant birds like the stately black-necked cranes. On the surrounding grasslands and slopes, you can see the magnificent kiang, the impressive argali sheep and the unusual Tibetan fox. The high point of my latest visit there was the culmination of a 40-year yearning—the sighting of Pallas's cat.*





Desert National Park

Temperature-wise, at the other end of the spectrum is the Desert National Park in **Rajasthan**. Another unique ecosystem, whose creatures have adapted to the dry and hot conditions. My favourites are the spiny-tailed lizards, the long-eared hedgehog and the now highly endangered Great Indian Bustard.

Photographs by INDIA PICTURE